

Study Questions: Planning

1. How does Active Inference formalize planning? What is the role of Expected Free Energy (EFE) in policy selection?
2. Explain the decomposition of EFE into risk and ambiguity. Give a concrete example of each.
3. What is sophisticated inference, and how does it extend basic policy selection?
4. How does Husserl's phenomenology of time-consciousness (retention, protention, living present) relate to the temporal structure of sophisticated inference?
5. What is Aristotle's concept of *telos* (final cause)? How does Active Inference relate to teleological explanation?
6. Is the C vector (prior preferences) evidence for genuine teleology, or merely "as if" teleology? Defend your position.
7. How does Heidegger's concept of *Dasein* as "being-toward" relate to Active Inference's account of planning?
8. What determines the temporal depth of planning? What are the cognitive and computational constraints?
9. How does Active Inference explain procrastination? What happens when the EFE landscape is flat?
10. How does Active Inference explain anxiety as a disorder of planning? What role does precision play?
11. Compare the Active Inference account of planning with classical AI search algorithms (e.g., minimax, Monte Carlo tree search). What are the key philosophical differences?
12. Is sophisticated inference (reasoning about what you will believe after acting) a form of self-knowledge? How does this relate to the Socratic imperative "know thyself"?
13. How does the concept of "temporal discounting" (preferring immediate over delayed rewards) appear in the Active Inference framework?
14. Can an agent plan without consciousness? What does planning in the absence of awareness look like in Active Inference?
15. How does the concept of narrative identity (MacIntyre, Ricoeur) relate to planning as inference over extended timescales?

16. What is the relationship between planning and imagination in Active Inference? Is imagining a future the same as planning for it?
17. How does the Active Inference account of planning handle genuine novelty — situations the agent has never encountered?
18. Compare the Active Inference account of planning with Frankfurt's distinction between first-order and second-order desires.
19. How does collective planning (political deliberation, organizational strategy) look from an Active Inference perspective?
20. Construct a philosophical argument: Does Active Inference's account of planning reduce human rationality to Bayesian computation, or does it reveal Bayesian computation to be richer than we thought?